Project: Worked examples
Title: Voltage drop and I²R loss
Status: DRAFT · Author: TempestOS (2026-10-23) · Checker: — (—) · Issued: —

1. Scope and method

Calculates the voltage drop, the conductor power loss and the estimated conductor temperature of a DC, single-phase or three-phase circuit. The drop limit is a user input, because the limits of BS 7671 are not embedded.

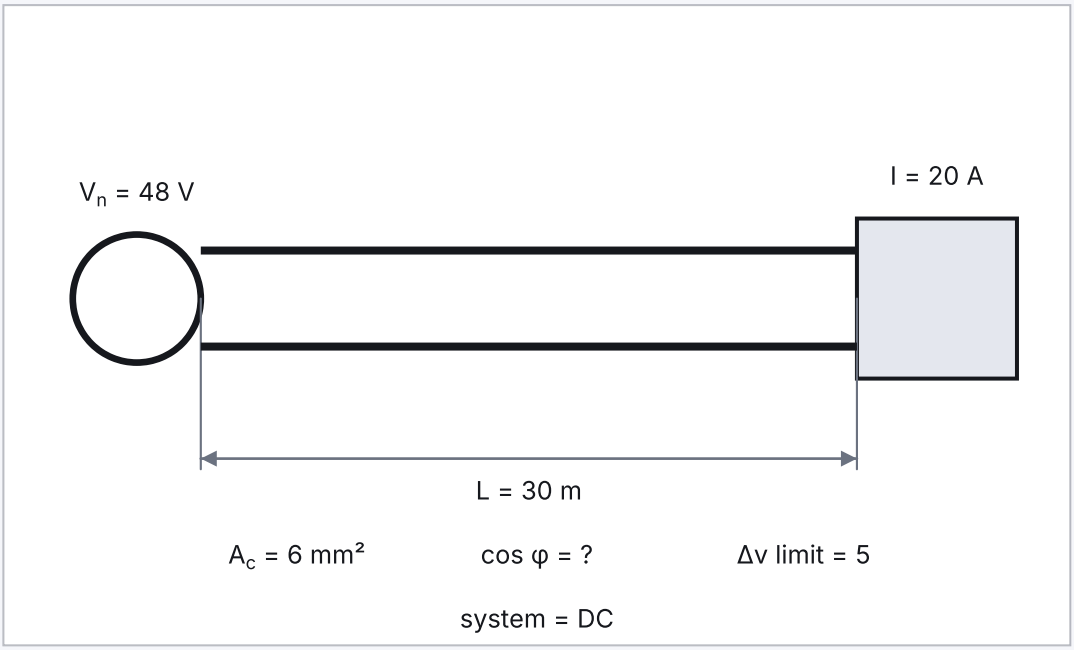


Figure 1 — A DC circuit: the supply, the two conductors of route length L, and the load current I. Not to scale; the labels are the inputs as entered.

WHAT IT CALCULATES	RELATION
Conductor resistance at its operating temperature, for n conductors in parallel	$R = \rho_T L/(A\ n)$, with $\rho_T = \rho_{20}\ [1 + \alpha\ (T_c - 20)]$
Resistance and reactance from per-length figures instead	$R = R'\ L/n$; $X = X'\ L/n$
Voltage drop on a DC circuit	$\Delta V = 2\ I\ R$
Voltage drop on a single-phase AC circuit	$\Delta V = 2\ I\ (R \cos\varphi + X \sin\varphi)$
Voltage drop on a three-phase AC circuit	$\Delta V = \sqrt{3}\ I\ (R \cos\varphi + X \sin\varphi)$
Voltage drop from a tabulated mV/A/m figure, which already carries the 2 or √3	$\Delta V = (mV/A/m)\ I\ L\ /\ 1000$
Power lost in the cable	$P_{loss} = 2\ I^2\ R$ (DC and single-phase); $3\ I^2\ R$ (three-phase)
Estimated conductor temperature at this current	$T_{c,est} = T_{amb} + (T_{rated} - T_{amb})(I/I_z)^2$

Basis: Voltage drop in consumers' installations[1](reg. 525); Voltage drop (mV/A/m tables and the temperature-correction method)[1](App. 4 §6); Resistance, resistivity and temperature coefficient[2](Ch. on DC and AC circuits, 12th ed. (edition to be checked)).

2. Inputs

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
system	System	DC		assumption: Design convention.	any
data	Conductor data from	resistivity and area		assumption: Design convention.	any
L	Route length (one way)	30	m	drawing: DRG-E-301 rev A	0.1 … 5000 m
n_{par}	Parallel conductors per phase	1		assumption: Design convention.	1 … 6
A_c	Conductor cross-section	6	mm²	spec: Cable schedule CS-02: 6 mm² Cu	1 … 1000 mm²
α	Temperature coefficient of resistance	0.00393		reference: Reference record: annealed copper (Hughes)	0.003 … 0.0045
X_{km}	Reactance per km per conductor	0	Ω/km	assumption: Design convention.	0 … 1 Ω/km
T_{rated}	Conductor rated temperature	70	°C	default	60 … 90 °C
ρ_{20}	Resistivity at 20 °C, the effective value for the conductor resistance (default 0.0194 Ω·mm²/m: the largest class 2 maximum conductor resistance of the cable standard for 1.5 to 120 mm², so the drop is not below the cable tables; pure annealed copper is 0.01724, aluminium 0.0282 Ω·mm²/m)	0.01724	Ω·mm²/m	reference: Reference record: annealed copper (Hughes)	0.01 … 0.05 Ω·mm²/m
V_n	Nominal voltage (line-to-line for three-phase)	48	V	assumption: Design convention.	12 … 1000 V
I	Design current	20	A	spec: Load schedule DC-02: 20 A	0.1 … 5000 A
cos_{phi}	Power factor (AC)	0.85		default	0.5 … 1
T_c	Conductor operating temperature for the resistance	70	°C	assumption: Design convention.	20 … 90 °C
T_{amb}	Ambient temperature	30	°C	default	0 … 60 °C

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
dv_{limit}	Voltage-drop limit	5		spec: Battery system spec BS-1: 5 % at the load	1 … 10

3. Assumptions

A1. The load is balanced across the phases. (Standard engineering approximation.)
A2. The conductor reactance is the entered X′ per kilometre times the length. (Standard engineering approximation.)
A3. The voltage drop is the arithmetic sum R cos φ + X sin φ, not the vector difference. (Standard engineering approximation.)
A4. A mV/A/m figure is used as tabulated, with its own temperature and system convention. (Cable table convention.)
A5. The estimated conductor temperature scales the rated temperature rise with $(I/I_z)^2$. (BS 7671:2018 Appendix 4 approach, formula only.)
A6. I_z is the tabulated capacity for the installation method, with its correction factors applied. (BS 7671:2018 Appendix 4 approach, formula only.)
A7. When the estimate is above T_c, the resistance and the drop are computed at the estimate. (Keeps the drop on the safe side.)
A8. system (System) is taken as DC. (Design convention.)
A9. data (Conductor data from) is taken as resistivity and area. (Design convention.)
A10. n_{par} (Parallel conductors per phase) is taken as 1. (Design convention.)
A11. X_{km} (Reactance per km per conductor) is taken as 0 Ω/km. (Design convention.)
A12. V_n (Nominal voltage (line-to-line for three-phase)) is taken as 48 V. (Design convention.)
A13. T_c (Conductor operating temperature for the resistance) is taken as 70 °C. (Design convention.)

4. Working

[9] $sin_{phi} = 0$
$= 0$
sin φ
[15] $\rho_T = \rho_{20} * (1 + \alpha * (T_c - 20\ degC) / (1\ K))$
$= 0.01724\ ohm·mm²/m \times (1 + 0.00393 \times (70\ degC - 20\ degC) / 1\ K)$
$= 0.020628\ ohm·mm²/m$
Resistivity at the operating temperature
[16] $R = \rho_T * L / (A_c * n_{par})$
$= 0.020628\ ohm·mm²/m \times 30\ m / (6\ mm² \times 1)$
$= 0.10314\ ohm$
Conductor resistance (one conductor, parallel paths combined)
[17] $X = X_{km} * L / n_{par}$
$= 0\ ohm/km \times 30\ m / 1$
$= 0\ ohm$
Conductor reactance
[18] $dV = 2 * I * R$
$= 2 \times 20\ A \times 0.10314\ ohm$
$= 4.1255\ V$
Voltage drop
[19] $dV_{pct} = 100 * dV / V_n$
$= 100 \times 4.1255\ V / 48\ V$
$= 8.5949$
Voltage drop, per cent
[20] $P_{loss} = 2 * I^2 * R$
$= 2 \times (20\ A)^2 \times 0.10314\ ohm$
$= 0.082511\ kW$

Conductor power loss

[21] $u_{dv} = dV_{pct} / dv_{limit}$

$= 8.5949 / 5$

$= 1.719$

Drop utilisation against the limit

[22] $dV_{max} = dv_{limit} / 100 * V_n$

$= 5 / 100 \times 48\ V$

$= 2.4\ V$

Largest voltage drop the limit allows

5. Results

SYMBOL	VALUE	DESCRIPTION
dV	4.126 V	Voltage drop
dV_{pct}	8.5949	Voltage drop (%)
P_{loss}	0.08251 kW	Power loss
R	0.1031 Ω	Resistance
X	0 Ω	Reactance
u_{dv}	1.72	Drop utilisation against the limit (governing)

6. Checks (governing first)

RESULT	CHECK	DEMAND	CAPACITY	UTILISATION	REF
FAIL	Voltage drop against the limit	4.126 V	2.400 V	1.72	[1](7671:2018 reg. 525)

7. Applicability

None.

Defaults used (inputs left empty):
T_{rated}: not entered, so the default of 70 °C is used.
cos_{phi}: not entered, so the default of 0.85 is used.
T_{amb}: not entered, so the default of 30 °C is used.

8. Verification

Template elec.voltage-drop@1.5.0 Content hash a149837c72d9fb56 Engine calc-engine/1.0.0
Known-answer cases passed 4/4 Test run 2026-10-23 12:00 UTC TempestOS 0.26.0

9. References

1. British Standards Institution; Institution of Engineering and Technology. Requirements for Electrical Installations: IET Wiring Regulations. BS 7671. IET.
2. Hughes E. Hughes Electrical and Electronic Technology. 12th ed. Pearson; 2016.